

[Office of International Student and Scholar Services](#)

How to File U.S. Taxes

Northwestern's Office of International Student and Scholar Services (OISS) coordinates access to Sprintax, an online tax preparation service designed specifically for nonresident international students and scholars in the United States.

Step 1: Attend a Sprintax Tax Webinar

Before filing, we strongly encourage you to attend a [Sprintax tax webinar \(/sprintax-tax-service.html\)](#), which explains U.S. tax obligations for international students and scholars and walks through the filing process.

Step 2: Receive Your Sprintax Access Code

OISS distributes Sprintax access codes by email to eligible F-1 and J-1 students and scholars by February 15.

- The code waives the federal tax preparation fee
- Please file as early as possible

Step 3: Gather Required Documents

Before logging into Sprintax, collect the following:

Personal & Immigration Documents

- Passport
- U.S. entry and exit dates (current and all prior visits or accessed in the travel history portion of your I-94 record on the CBP website)
- Form I-20 (F-1) or DS-2019 (J-1)
- Social Security Number (SSN) or Individual Taxpayer Identification Number (ITIN), if applicable

A SSN or ITIN is not required if you had no U.S. income and only need to file Form 8843.

If you need an ITIN, refer to the [ITIN Eligibility resource \(/itin-eligibility.html\)](#)

Tax & Income Documents (if applicable) : For more information on which tax forms you may need for Sprintax to file your tax return, see the [Foreign National Tax Team's website \(/https://hr.northwestern.edu/essentials/pay-taxes/foreign-nationals/#tab-panel1\)](#).

- W-2 (employment wages)
- 1042-S (stipends, scholarships, treaty benefits, certain services)
- 1099 (interest, dividends, freelance or miscellaneous income)
- Final pay slips (if helpful for reference)

You may receive multiple forms, or none at all, depending on your circumstances. Do not file your taxes with Sprintax until you have received all of the required tax & income documents.

Step 4: Log Into Sprintax Using Your OISS Code

Sprintax is an easy to use tax preparation software designed for nonresident tax filers. It guides you through the tax process and determines which forms you must file.

Go to Sprintax and:

- Log in using an existing account from a previous year, or
- Create a new account if this is your first time using Sprintax

Enter your OISS Sprintax access code during checkout to apply to the federal filing waiver.

Step 5: Determine Your Tax Residency Status

After logging in, Sprintax will ask questions about the time you have spent in the U.S. and determine your residency for tax purposes using IRS [Substantial Presence Test](https://www.irs.gov/individuals/international-taxpayers/substantial-presence-test#https://www.irs.gov/individuals/international-taxpayers/substantial-presence-test) (<https://www.irs.gov/individuals/international-taxpayers/substantial-presence-test#https://www.irs.gov/individuals/international-taxpayers/substantial-presence-test>).

General Guidelines of the Substantial Presence Test

- F-1 and J-1 students are generally nonresidents for their first five calendar years in the U.S.
- J-1 scholars and researchers are generally nonresidents for two calendar years (out of the past six), including any prior F-1 or J-1 time.

Sprintax automatically applies these rules based on your responses.

Step 6: File Based on Your Residency Status

If You Are a Nonresident

If Sprintax determines you are nonresident for tax purposes, you may continue using the software. Sprintax will help you:

- Identify required tax forms
- Determine eligibility for tax treaty benefits
- Generate completed federal tax documents with filing instructions

You will typically need to print, sign, and mail your federal tax return to the IRS. In some cases, you may be eligible to e-file, depending on IRS criteria.

If You Are a Resident

Sprintax cannot be used by resident tax filers. If Sprintax determines you are a resident, you should consider one of the following options:

- File directly through the [IRS website](https://freefilealliance.org/) (<https://freefilealliance.org/>).
- Use resident tax software (e.g., TurboTax or H&R Block)
- Hire a [Certified Public Accountant](https://ayoungllc.com/) (<https://ayoungllc.com/>) (CPA) to assist with filing taxes

Step 7: Complete State Tax Filing (If Required)

Sprintax access codes do not cover state tax filing fees.

If you have a state tax filing requirement, you have three options you may choose from to complete your filing requirements:

1. Pay Sprintax to prepare your state tax return for an additional fee
2. Hire a [Certified Public Accountant](https://ayoungllc.com/) (<https://ayoungllc.com/>)
3. File your state taxes on your own
 1. <https://tax.illinois.gov/> (<https://tax.illinois.gov/#https://tax.illinois.gov/>)

Need Help While Using Sprintax?

OISS cannot assist you with questions you may have while using Sprintax. Sprintax provides direct support to users:

- Email: hello@sprintax.com (<mailto:hello@sprintax.com>)
- [24/7](https://returnssupport.sprintax.com/hc/en-us) (<https://returnssupport.sprintax.com/hc/en-us>) Live Chat (available after logging into your Sprintax account)

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